

Why Are We Edified?

We graduated to Romans 8:26 and found out that Paul explained the very like manner in which the Holy Spirit helps our infirmities. Infirmities break down to mean your and my inability to produce results because of the limitations imposed on us by this flesh.

Then we found out that, in this like manner, He helps us walk out of domination by the flesh and into liberty in the Holy Ghost.

This is how He does it:

Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities:
for we know not what we should pray for as we ought:
but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us
with groanings which cannot be uttered.

When you do not know how to pray as you ought, the Holy Spirit lends Himself to you in a supernatural language. He searches your heart to find out your problem and why you are failing. He searches your heart for the sole purpose of praying the mind of God, the will of God, into your life.

Once again, the very basics of His will are this: that I be delivered, free, and set free from every damnable thing Jesus said I am free from. That includes poverty, sickness, disease, pain, lack of peace, or whatever He set me free from.

The very basics of His will, being executed by my attorney, the Holy Spirit, are to see that I am set free from those charges and released into the glorious liberty of everything Jesus said I am.

You and I know that He portrayed tongues, groanings, and intercessions as a major key to this walk of the Spirit, a major key to releasing the ability of Him within us.

When I found out that tongues was a major key, one I could execute anytime at my own will, that I could pray as much as I wanted to in tongues, I thought, "My God, what on the face of this earth can stop me anymore?"

When I found out tongues was a major key, do you not think I studied it? When you go after what sets you free, do you not think I studied tongues? It fascinated me.

Do you not think I meditated on it until my meditator almost fell out on the ground? Do you not think I got great books, interlinears and outerlinears, exteriors, interiors, roofs, leaks, and finally Strong's, and exhausted everything they said about anything?

My God, man, if faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God, then I wanted to hear everything the Word of God had to say about this.

If He is guaranteeing me that tongues plays such a major role in helping my infirmities, in loosing me from every damnable thing that has endeavored to bring me to a standstill, then would it not behoove you to find out everything you can about it, and how to wield it as a weapon of God more accurately in your life?

Jude 20 says:

But ye, beloved,
building up yourselves on your most holy faith,
praying in the Holy Ghost.

My question to God was, "Building myself up where? Up where on my most holy faith?"

Building yourselves up above a walk dominated by the flesh into a glorious, liberated walk of the Spirit by praying in the Holy Ghost.

This fascinated me because of how much I had cried for faith. In the early years of this ministry, I bawled for faith.

"Oh God, if I had more faith, do You know what I would do?"

Then I would tell Him everything I would do. I converted my emotions into H₂O and cried all night for God to give me more faith. All I did was get wet.

Yet all the time, right under my nose, was a verse that guaranteed the very thing my heart pounded for. "Ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith." It guaranteed a building up, right under our nose. But we passed it up, taking it only at face value.

If we really wanted faith that badly, my God, why could some of us not begin to do what it said? It guaranteed us a building up of our most holy faith.

According to all the teaching I received in the first four years of my walk in faith, faith only came one way:

Faith cometh by hearing,
and hearing by the word of God.

If that is the way faith comes, I could not understand how speaking a bunch of syllables in the air could bring an increase to anyone's faith.

I said, "Lord, how in the world could that bring an increase to anyone's faith? You said faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God. That I can comprehend with my natural mind. Once I find out what God said about my problem, not the devil, not the flesh, not the world, then, brother, that is it. I know the will of God. It releases my faith because I know what God said about it."

If that is how faith comes, I could not understand how He could make such a bold statement:

But ye, beloved,
building up yourselves on your most holy faith,
praying in the Holy Ghost.

It took a little while, only about six years, but my lightning-quick mind finally caught on that somehow praying in tongues must offer itself as an assistance to my understanding of the Word of God. Faith really only comes by hearing what the Word said about your problem.

So I launched out with this in my spirit: somehow praying in tongues must offer itself as an assistance to my understanding of the Word of God. As it panned out, thank God, I was right.

When I first began to suspect this, when my lightning-quick mind first grasped these truths, I thought I would go to those who seemed to be somewhat among them and ask them first, to save myself a lot of time.

I said, "Why are we edified when we pray in tongues? Why?"

"Oh, do you not know, brother?"

I said, "No, I do not."

"We edify ourselves, and the Greek breakdown on edify means it would be proper to say that we actually receive a charge."

I said, "You mean edify breaks down to mean a charge?"

"Yes, it does."

"You mean like a battery?"

"Yes, you got it."

"You mean like at the gas station: negative, positive, charge? That kind of charge?"

"Yes, because faith is a tangible substance. It is tangible. You can feel it, and you are receiving a tangible charge."

I said, "You mean if I speak in tongues, then I do not have to know any more of the Word? I do not have to know anything, and then I can sneak up on somebody with 220 volts, and that is why they go down under the power? Is that what you mean by edify?"

"Yes, that is it."

"How much do you pray in tongues?"

"Oh, well, I like to study."

"Is that where you found out about edify?"

"Oh yes."

My lightning-quick mind went ahead and took that third-grade explanation for a while, for lack of anything deeper. But I was in the habit of praying in the Holy Ghost anyway, so I could not stay in that very long.

I thought it was that way because in some of my first meetings I would go and pray for people, and they would fall down on the floor. I really thought that was neat. One day they started falling down when I did not touch them, and I thought, "Wow, this is a power field."

My mind accepted that third-grade explanation for a long time.

For this cause, I am still thanking God for First Corinthians 14, because there is a revelation contained in the first three verses that set me so free that, from that day to this, I still have trouble standing myself.

The reason is because I know how to work the perfect plan of God in my life. Yes, because I want to.

We should probably take a look at this, would you say? If it is in like manner that the Spirit helps our infirmities, would it not behoove you and me to look at it?

First Corinthians 14 begins:

Follow after charity,
and desire spiritual gifts,
but rather that ye may prophesy.
For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue
speaketh not unto men,
but unto God:
for no man understandeth him;
howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

When he says, "Follow after love in action and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that you may prophesy," he was not really saying prophecy was greater than speaking with tongues. The whole thrust of this letter to the Corinthians, especially in chapter 14, was that they should excel to the place where they edified the entire body.

In doing so, he says tongues that equals prophecy is tongues that is interpreted. A man who speaks with tongues for personal edification is talking to God. But a man who prophesies is speaking to people for edification.

So Paul had to differentiate in absolute detail between tongues that works inwardly on me and tongues for interpretation that equals prophecy and edifies you. Because he differentiated between the two, you and I can glean the answer.

Sometimes I think Paul was smart. In passing, in two or three verses, he strokes a revelation in there that takes me about six years to get out.

He differentiated between the other operations of tongues: tongues for intercession, tongues for interpretation, tongues as a sign to the unbeliever, and finally tongues for personal edification. Because he drew that one out by the Spirit, you and I can draw it out too.

He says:

He that speaketh in an unknown tongue
speaketh not unto men,
but unto God:
for no man understandeth him.

If I were speaking in tongues to be interpreted, then somebody would have to understand it. But he says no man understands this one because it is nobody else's business. It is between me, my spirit, and God my Father. It is for my own personal edification. It is designed to help my infirmities.

I do not know about you, but this gets me so excited that I can hardly stand myself.

In the early days, when I first began to realize this revelation, I would train people. Old Tim McFall did not give me any choice but to train him.

He saw God perform a miracle on a woman's foot. She could not move her foot, and at the moment of prayer, the thing absolutely unlocked, all the pain left, and she could move it.

Tim was a Baptist boy who had been filled with the Holy Ghost approximately one year. He got so close to watch that miracle that he jammed his head between me and her foot.

I said, "Tim, please."

After he saw that miracle, he said, "I am going to follow you until I get what you have."

I thought, "Sure. I have heard that before."

One man showed up at my doorstep. In those days, I was naive, ignorant, and on top of that, dumb. I thought everybody who said God sent him had really been sent by God.

He said, "I am going to get what you have."

I said, "All right."

I was in a routine. Did you know he came Friday and God told him to leave Monday? I cannot figure out why. All I did was pray in tongues twelve hours a day and give him two cups of coffee over the weekend. He wanted to do what I did, and God changed his mind.

Tim McFall said, "I am going to follow you until I get what you have."

I thought, "Sure, sure."

But every time I went somewhere, Tim was sitting in the crowd. Finally I said, "Man, do you not work?"

He said, "I told you what I was going to do."

Finally, in prayer, God said, "What are you going to do about Tim McFall?"

You might as well tell Him what is in your heart. I said, "Nothing."

He said, "Oh yes, you are."

I said, "I am?"

He said, "Yes, you are. You are going to oversee his training."

I said, "But..."

He said, "You are going to do it."

So you know what I did? I bootlegged sixty-six Kenneth Hagin tapes. Bootlegging is when the label says, "Do not copy," and you copy them.

I gave them to Tim and said, "What do you do for a living?"

He said, "I drive a forklift at night."

I said, "Okay, Tim. I want you to listen to these tapes, totally concentrate on them, six times apiece. On top of that, I want you to lock yourself up in seclusion. None of this walking around praying. I want you totally concentrating on your prayer life. Do nothing else. Report to the closet, and pray six hours a day in tongues, nonstop. The only thing you had better do is drink water. Listen to those tapes, pray, and in six months come back to me, and I will give you your next step."

I thought to myself, "You got rid of him."

Four months later, I came to Tim McFall's town for a miracle crusade. In those days, we had people stand up who had been healed in the last meeting.

I said, "Has anybody been healed lately in these crusades?"

One woman stood up and said, "I had a deaf ear. At the moment of prayer, it literally popped open."

I said, "Really? Which one of my services did that happen in?"

She said, "It was not yours at all. It was Tim McFall's."

I said, "Sit down, lady."

Another woman had the audacity to stand up and say, "My brother was in an insane asylum."

I said, "Yes?"

She said, "At the moment of prayer, God heard us because I stood in proxy. The next morning he woke up sane, and they had to let him out."

I thought, "My God, this is newsletter material. Which one of my services did that happen in?"

She said, "It was not yours at all. It was Tim McFall's."

I said, "Sit down, lady."

After a while, Tim came in, and I said, "Tim, would you mind waiting until the service is over?"

Then he waited for me. Pretty soon I said, "Tim, can I drive you anywhere?"

We were sitting in the car, and I was thinking, "I have borne the burden and heat of the day. I have been filled with the Holy Ghost for eight years. Tim has only been filled a little over a year, and You have made him equal. You are paying him the same as You are paying me."

I was dying to kill him.

I said, "Tim, what happened?"

He said, "You are joking, are you not?"

I said, "No."

He said, "You are really asking me?"

I said, "What happened, Tim? What in the world did you do?"

He said, "What did I do?"

I said, "Yes, what did you do?"

He said, "You are joking."

I said, "No."

He said, "I did what you told me to do."

I said, "Really?"

He said, "Yes."

"It really works, does it not, Tim? I told you, did I not?"

I said, "God, this is phenomenal. What could mark such a tremendous difference in the spirit of a man?"

It was simply this:

He that speaketh in an unknown tongue
speaketh not unto men,
but unto God.

With my physical man, I contact physical things. I can grasp this pulpit. With my soul, which is my mind, will, intellect, and emotional faculties, I can communicate with my fellow man. You and I can make contact.

But Jesus revealed God as Spirit, and He said those who worship Him must worship Him in spirit and in truth.

When I rear back and speak with tongues, instantly my human spirit has made contact with God Himself.

I said, "Heavenly Father, this is the only diversity of the gifts of the Spirit. Even tongues for edification is only one diversity of tongues, but it is meant for my own edification. All the other gifts flow outward for the edification of others, whether it is word of wisdom, word of knowledge, healings, workings of miracles, interpretation of tongues, or intercessional groanings. But tongues for personal edification I can activate at my own will."

It is not that I operate tongues. God made me the steward of its operation because it is designed to edify me. It works inward. Therefore I can activate it as an act of my will and my faith because He gave me the stewardship of the operation of tongues for personal edification.

This is for you hungry, hungry people who do not want to be stopped.

Hallelujah.

I thought, "God, why did You choose such a language as this?"

When I heard the explanation, the mystery of it rolled through my spirit. I got so excited it took days to wear off. I grabbed my pencil, just like Paul grabbed his quill, and I wrote as fast as I could.

He said to me, "Son, among men there is no language that has ever been created that has the vocabulary to express everything I am through Jesus Christ to you."

That is heavy.

The devil does not understand my language. You have got it. This prayer is between me and God, and it is designed inwardly for my personal edification.

What does edification mean? It means to receive a charge, to be built up on your most holy faith.

The whole world has looked to you and me for an answer: "Why do you pray in tongues?" The church world that does not speak with tongues has looked at us and wanted answers.

"Why do you do it?"

We look at them and say, "That is the initial evidence that I am filled with the Holy Ghost."

"You mean I am not?"

"Well, no, I did not exactly say that."

"Then why do you think you are better than me? Why do you speak in tongues?"

"To be interpreted."

"Then if there is no interpreter, you had better be quiet, buddy. Be quiet."

"No, I am praying for my own edification."

"Why are you edified?"

"It charges me up like a battery."

"Why?"

"Do you know what you are saying?"

"No, not all the time."

"Then why does it do it? I want to know why. Why do you do it?"

"It builds me up on my most holy faith."

"How does it do that?"

"The Bible just says it does."

"But I want to know how."

"Just take it by faith."

That is what they are trying to do. But faith comes by hearing. Would you believe that Paul answered all those questions in the second half of this second verse?

Look closely:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue
speaketh not unto men,
but unto God:
for no man understandeth him;
howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

"Howbeit" is analytical. It analyzes the whole situation. If I am speaking in tongues and it is not to be interpreted, yet I am talking to God, and no man understands me, then what is transpiring in the world of the Spirit?

How be it?

He says:

In the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

I knew that if I could ever break down the word "mysteries" in the Greek, I would have the answer to why our most holy faith is increased from praying in tongues.

He said I am speaking mysteries. What in the world are mysteries? Whatever they are, He said I am speaking them.

Before we break this down, let us read a little more:

But he that prophesieth
speaketh unto men
to edification,
and exhortation,
and comfort.
He that speaketh in an unknown tongue
edifieth himself;
but he that prophesieth
edifieth the church.

If I were to prophesy to you and say, "Thus saith the Lord, if everyone will raise your hands, you shall be healed," of course you would be edified. Why? The mind of God would be executed in your midst. You would know what He wanted for that moment. You would all raise your hands, and if it was a true word from God, every single one of you would be healed. You would be edified, comforted, and exhorted.

He who prophesies edifies the church because the mind of God is revealed. But he who speaks in an unknown tongue edifies himself.

The reasons for the edification are the same, because you are praying mysteries and divine secrets. These divine secrets and mysteries are actually the mind of God, but in this instance it is not collective; it is individual. You are praying the mind of God into your life for that moment.

I could get excited over this.

I remember when I first started praying extended amounts in tongues. It was fun. At first it was hard. The real battle was with myself to stay in the closet. But I did not have any choice.

I had gone full-time and had three little kids. Our cupboards were empty, just barely enough to feed them. I was pastoring a church of six people. My only tithe payer went broke. I wanted to preach, but nobody would let me.

"Do you have any prior experience?"

"No, that is what I am trying to get."

"We are sorry."

I finally booked a little hall for five dollars a night. I bluffed my way in.

"Dave Roberson Ministries is in town. We want to rent your hall. Would you please charge my home office?"

My home office was my front room. My secretary was my wife.

Then I went to the paper in town, one of those that comes out once a week on Tuesday. The town had about three thousand people. I bluffed my way in and ran a twelve-dollar ad.

I will never forget it. There were five strangers sitting in that hall. I had a fifteen-year-old front man who sang every song he could think of, and I was afraid to come out of the back room.

Finally I came out, took a deep breath, got behind the microphone, squared off, and told them everything I knew in about fifteen minutes.

But God was with me.

The months went by, and I kept praying these extended amounts of time in tongues. A good friend of mine, Earl Hitchens, introduced me to the faith message.

Earl Hitchens was one of those loggers you see in the movies: four-wheel-drive rig, big bright red suspenders, dungaree pants split up to the knee, big logging brogans with steel toes, and a chainsaw in his back pocket.

He would say, "Davey, you want to know about faith?"

So he taught me faith.

But I kept praying in tongues, and then I would meditate. I would pray a certain number of hours, then get the Word out and start reading. All of a sudden, verses would come alive to me.

I thought, "My God, I have read that five hundred times. How come all of a sudden I have insight into that verse? This is amazing."

I remember the day it dawned on me that I had a new car. It was one of those mysteries over poverty. I was meditating, and I had read it a thousand times. All of a sudden, I went, "Whoa, my God."

I got Earl Hitchens and said, "Look at this verse. Have you ever seen this?"

He looked at me. I looked at him. I explained that verse to him in detail.

He said, "I think I am getting it."

I said, "Look, Earl, it is simple."

This was because I had spent three months in prayer.

"Look at it, Earl. Can you not see it?"

He looked at it. "I think I am getting it."

I explained it fifteen times. Finally he said, "It is starting to come. I think I am seeing what you are seeing."

Two weeks later, I was driving around in a brand-new Volkswagen van off the showroom floor, and I owned every bolt in it. It was mine.

After that revelation hit me, I went into town and claimed a Volkswagen at midnight because I only had twenty-five cents. There was no high-pressure salesman. Brother, I knew I had it.

I preached a little meeting. They were all little. After I was done, I said, "Earl, do you remember when I showed you that revelation?"

He said, "Yes."

Then I unfolded a check. Somebody had thrown five thousand dollars into the offering. I want you to know I went down and paid cash for that Volkswagen van. I made them give me the one on the showroom floor.

"Get all the other cars out of the way. Get them out of the way."

I got in that thing and cranked it up, and the new upholstery smell hit me in the nostrils. I got drunk smelling it. Every fifteen miles, I wanted to stop, get out, and hug the front of it.

I was bawling, aching all over with the goodness of God. I remember lifting my face to heaven and bawling like a little baby. He said to me, "Son, you have just been bathed in My grace, and this is a love gift from your Father."

I bet you are wondering what mystery that was.

It was the mystery of grace concerning giving. I used to give like crazy according to law, trying to earn the standing Jesus had already said was mine. Then I found out that by grace, His unmerited, unearnable favor, He was made my poverty and turned around and gave me His standing.

All I needed was to know that by revelation. I had been trying to earn that standing by law. When I found out by an act of grace that He had made me rich, I quit giving to try to be what He said I was. I started giving because I already knew I was, just like I knew I was righteous.

Then I thought, "How come I am getting these revelations? It must be because I am called to preach. After all, what would I preach if God did not show favoritism toward me and give me these kinds of revelations? That must be it. It is my call."

Then I heard some real stupid preachers, and I knew that was not true.

So I said, "Why, God? Why is this coming?"

He kept bringing me back to:

Howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

I said, "Father God, what mysteries are You talking about?"

I found out from the Greek that it is exactly the same rendering as the mysteries proclaimed to be hidden in God from the foundation of the world, but now made available to you and me through the ministry of the Holy Ghost in this dispensation of grace.

I said, "Let me get this straight. You mean the mysteries that have been hidden in You since before the world was are the same ones I am penetrating the throne room of grace with every time I speak with tongues?"

He said, "You have got it."

The Holy Spirit continued to expound within me and said, "Why do you think Paul made such a brazen, bold statement to hundreds of thousands of Corinthians, 'I thank my God I speak with tongues more than ye all'?"

Paul was responsible for three-quarters of the revelation knowledge contained in the New Testament, especially in the areas of grace. By his own mouth, he had said, "I have been made a minister of the mysteries of the kingdom of God."

How could he minister them if he had not understood them?

Folks, it went something like this. Paul walked from city to city. If he spoke in tongues more than every man, woman, and child in the entire Corinthian church, what do you think his days were filled with as he walked from town to town?

He prayed in tongues. And the pilot of one of his camels might say, "What did you say, Paul?"

Paul would say, "Never mind. I am not talking to you. I am talking to God."

At night, when he pitched his tent, he prayed. All of a sudden, while he was lying there, I can see it because it has happened to me so many times. He would be awakened. He would grab his quill, grab his inkwell, dip the quill into the ink, and write as fast as he could.

God got hold of his letters, and He thought so much of them that He made them a permanent part of the Word of God and called them epistles. Contained within those epistles are the divine secrets, the mysteries that were hidden in God but now lie recorded in that Bible sitting in your lap.

Why in the world is your faith increased when you pray in tongues? It is not because of some electrical, tangible charge you receive from speaking a bunch of syllables in the air.

The reason you are edified and charged like a battery is because you are speaking those same mysteries: the mystery of healing, the mystery of righteousness, the mystery of redemption. You are speaking them before the throne room of grace.

God, like with any other prayer, answers them. When He does, those Scriptures come alive, and faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God.